This is Erin Dawson’s content design portfolio.

I design the systems behind product language: voice standards, tone boundaries, and workflows that help teams write clearly, consistently, and responsibly at scale.

Across these case studies, I focus less on individual lines of copy and more on the problems language is used to solve—navigating ambiguity, aligning stakeholders, managing risk, and translating complex ideas for diverse audiences. Much of this work lives upstream of final deliverables, where copy functions as infrastructure: a way to establish shared understanding before products, programs, or policies fully take shape.

The examples below reflect how I approach content as a design system—defined by constraints, documented decisions, and repeatable processes—rather than as one-off writing exercises.

NOTE ON STYLE GUIDE SAMPLES
I’ve also authored and maintained internal voice and style guides used by multiple teams; I’m happy to share excerpts or walk through them during interviews.

Case Study: Establishing a Trustworthy Voice for a New Community Program

Oracle Luminaries, a developer community

CONTEXT

This program launched under evolving organizational conditions, requiring careful tone calibration to avoid overpromising or misalignment.

Luminaries was an ultimately aborted developer group for Oracle users seeking troubleshooting support, virtual/IRL community, and career investment through badges and discounted certification. Its current status is up in the air. Signs point to it being subsumed into Oracle’s ACEs program.

Because this was a new program, a new voice was needed. That voice would be used for eBlasts, Slack blocks and tweets, in addition to blogs and an Eloqua registration page.

TASK: Voice Goals and Constraints

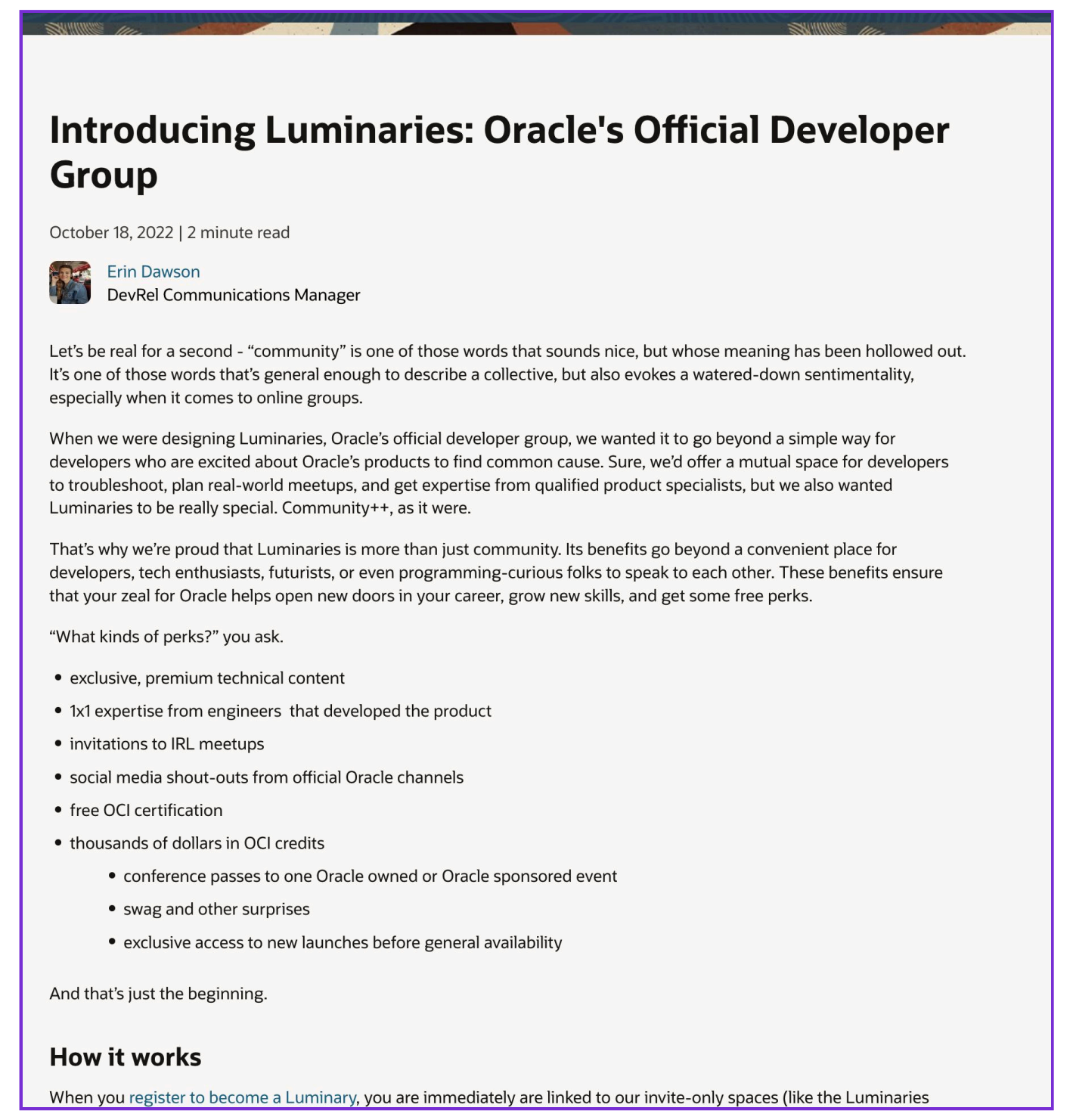
The task was to create a voice that was, on one hand, confident and resolute about the program’s benefits, and on the other, imparted sincere joy about how much the potential registrant would gain from this community.

ACTION: System, Rollout, and Decisions

Luminaries Blog post

I first fleshed out this voice most when writing the blog. Using my own feelings about the word “community” and the quasi-corporate tone of a professional developer group, the blog is a frank document that drives toward its CTA of registration. Its air is one of “I know you’ve heard something like this before, but this time it’s different” without being too gimmicky.

In the blog, I used a collective “we” to emphasize community on both ends of this equation - the community that this program sought to create and the community of real human beings behind the design of Luminaries. I also used some subtle developer dog whistling with “Community++.”



Introducing Luminaries: Oracle's Official Developer Group

October 18, 2022 | 2 minute read

Erin Dawson
DevRel Communications Manager

Let’s be real for a second - “community” is one of those words that sounds nice, but whose meaning has been hollowed out. It’s one of those words that’s general enough to describe a collective, but also evokes a watered-down sentimentality, especially when it comes to online groups.

When we were designing Luminaries, Oracle’s official developer group, we wanted it to go beyond a simple way for developers who are excited about Oracle’s products to find common cause. Sure, we’d offer a mutual space for developers to troubleshoot, plan real-world meetups, and get expertise from qualified product specialists, but we also wanted Luminaries to be really special. Community++, as it were.

That’s why we’re proud that Luminaries is more than just community. Its benefits go beyond a convenient place for developers, tech enthusiasts, futurists, or even programming-curious folks to speak to each other. These benefits ensure that your zeal for Oracle helps open new doors in your career, grow new skills, and get some free perks.

“What kinds of perks?” you ask.

- exclusive, premium technical content
- 1x1 expertise from engineers that developed the product
- invitations to IRL meetups
- social media shout-outs from official Oracle channels
- free OCI certification
- thousands of dollars in OCI credits
    - conference passes to one Oracle owned or Oracle sponsored event
    - swag and other surprises
    - exclusive access to new launches before general availability

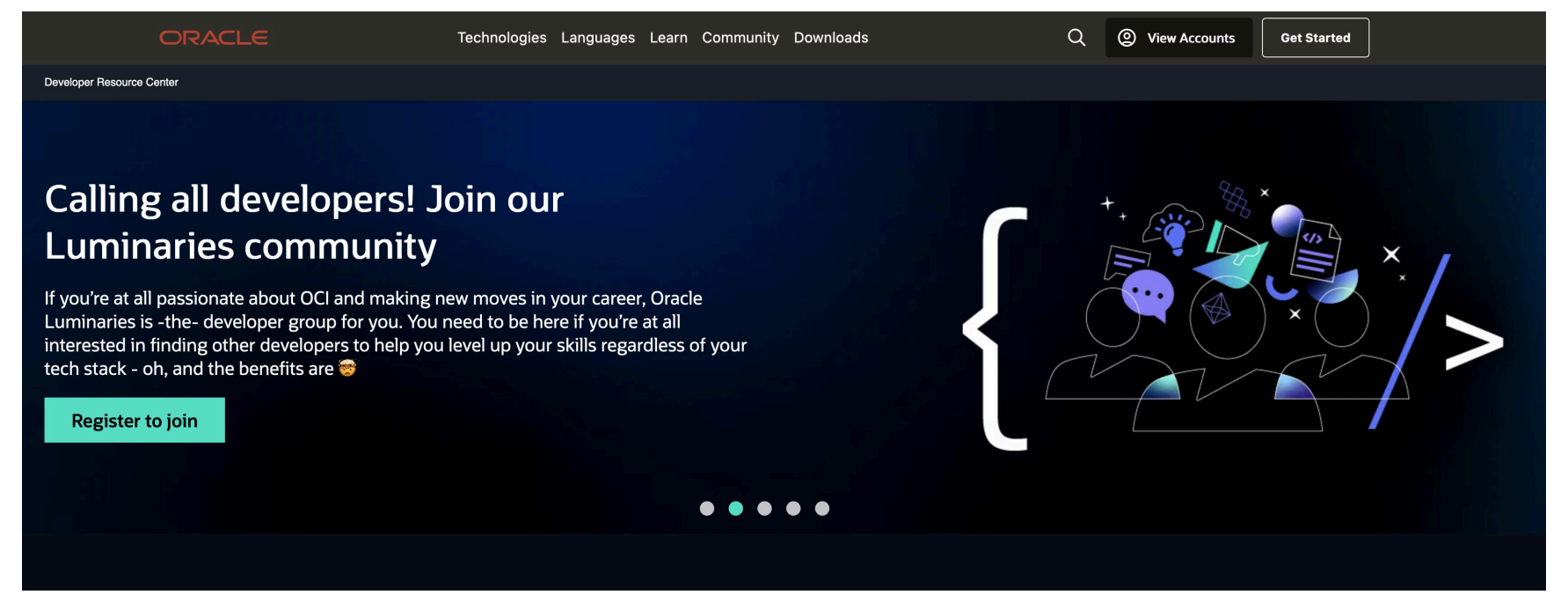
And that’s just the beginning.

How it works

When you register to become a Luminary, you are immediately are linked to our invite-only spaces (like the Luminaries

Webcopy and Registration page

The developer.oracle carousel copy and registration page continue in this vein by using a tone that makes joining this community a common sense decision for career minded developers.

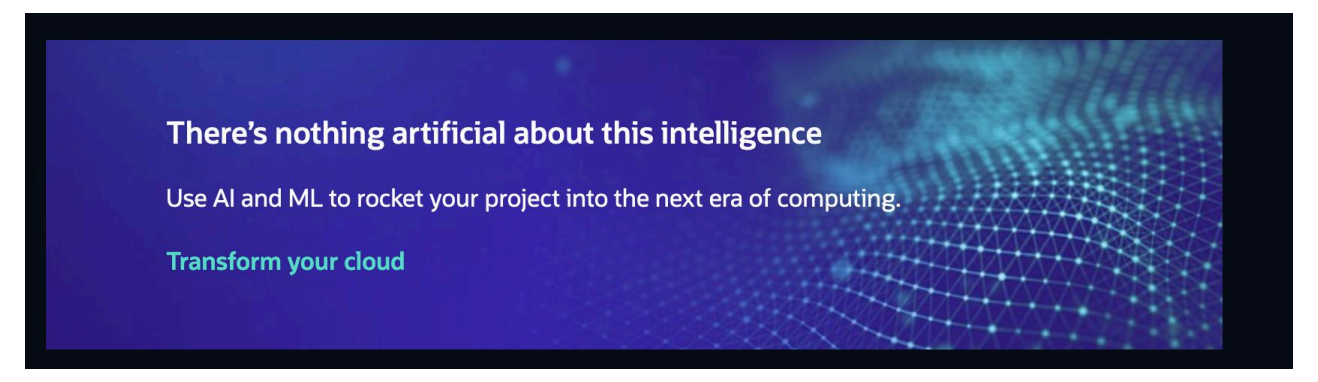


Calling all developers! Join our Luminaries community

If you’re at all passionate about OCI and making new moves in your career, Oracle Luminaries is -the- developer group for you. You need to be here if you’re at all interested in finding other developers to help you level up your skills regardless of your tech stack - oh, and the benefits are 😎

Register to join

I’ve included a third screenshot (“There’s nothing artificial about this intelligence”) that also captures a similar tone. Though not Luminaries copy, I’m using the copy that I’ve written elsewhere as a guide for the Luminaries voice.



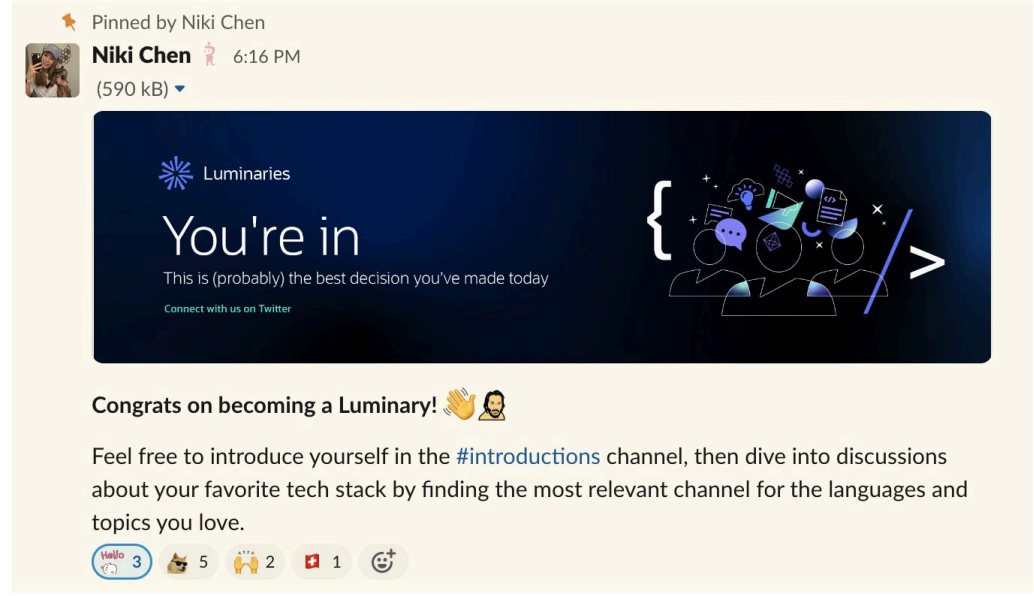
There’s nothing artificial about this intelligence

Use AI and ML to rocket your project into the next era of computing.

Transform your cloud

Slack block

Here again, I’ve flexed the kind of bravada needed for aspiring confidence in a new community. The CTA begins with a verb, “Connect,” that also evokes community (as in, more community awaits when you connect).


Luminaries
You're in
This is (probably) the best decision you've made today
Connect with us on Twitter

Pinned by Niki Chen
Niki Chen 6:16 PM
(590 kB)

Congrats on becoming a Luminary! 👋

Feel free to introduce yourself in the #introductions channel, then dive into discussions about your favorite tech stack by finding the most relevant channel for the languages and topics you love.

3 5 2 1

RESULTS

Due to the stalling of development and inclusion into the ACEs program, it’s difficult to say how successful this copy was relative to how successful we would have been if this program received buy-in from leadership.

Less objectively speaking, I do believe this tone to be a good fit for a new program like this. The confidence and frankness of this voice seemed necessary given Oracle’s (continued) mixed messaging regarding exactly how important developer communities are to them. That confidence was built in to reassure Oracle developers that we wouldn’t drop the ball this time.

WHAT WOULD I CHANGE?

The webcopy/carousel copy is the weakest here, in retrospect. Emoji looks out of place in hero copy. It doesn’t explain what benefits a developer would enjoy from joining the group and doesn’t leverage illumination imagery, which seems like a missed opportunity (though if memory serves, we tried a bit of that and it didn’t feel at home with the tone).

Case Study: Establishing a Playful Product Voice Without Undermining Trust

Pi Day 2022

CONTEXT

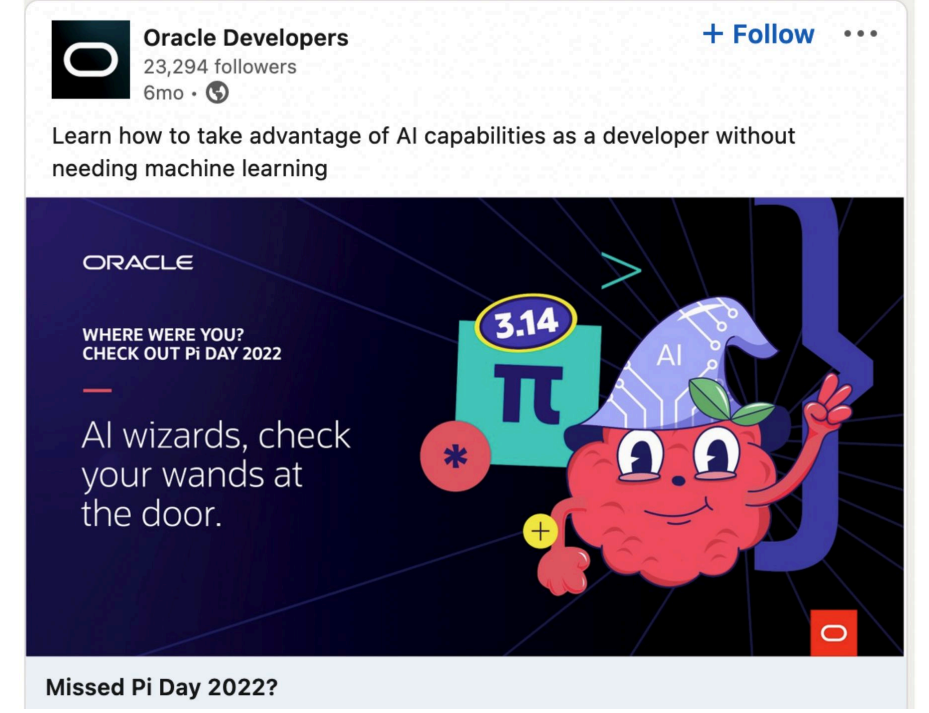
This event, facilitated by the DevRel team, used the 3/14 date as a way to engage developers for a day of labs and demos. Stakeholders requested an energetic, playful, and colorful tone which would lean into modern notions of internet absurdity and lighthearted nerdery.

CONSTRAINTS AND GOALS

The task was to create a voice that increased developer engagement through event registration. That voice was to strike an inviting confidence without any hint of a sales pitch. After establishing that voice, the task was to write web copy, social posts, social tiles, blog posts, and even a brief comedic sketch.

SYSTEM AND DECISIONS

While collaborating with the Brand team, primarily Ethan Johnson and Andre Martin, I wanted to combine technical language with notions of world building and fantasy, which would ideally trigger developers’ love for gaming. “AI wizards, check your wand at the door” evoked, perhaps, trainees studying AI, preparing to enter a lesson, laying down their wands to listen to a (pointy-hatted) sage and engage with the craft further.



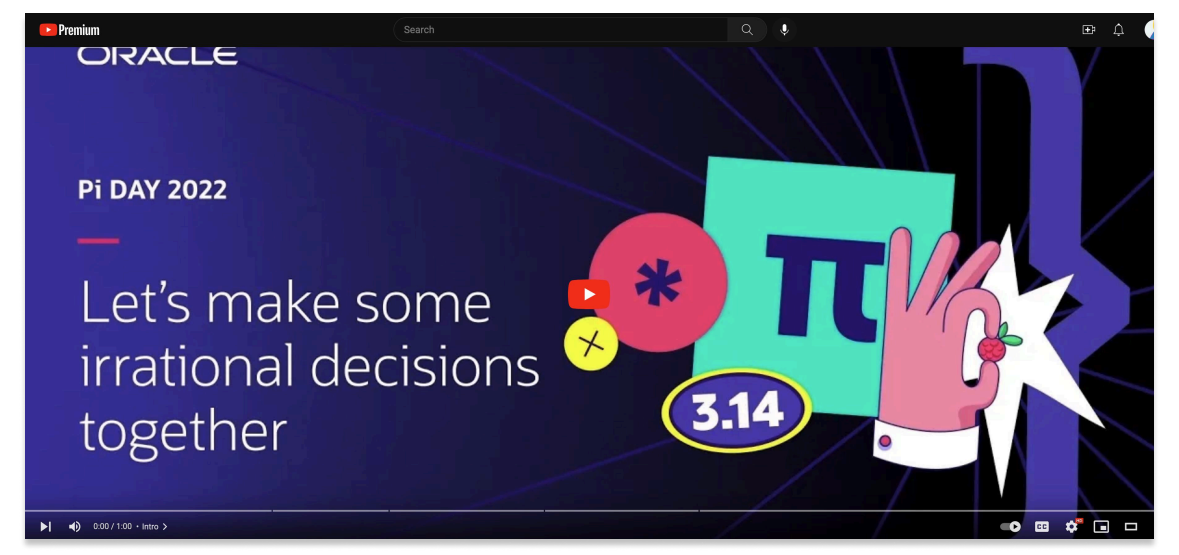
Learn how to take advantage of AI capabilities as a developer without needing machine learning

AI wizards, check your wands at the door.

Missed Pi Day 2022?

While looking for tonal inspiration, I did a little research and found that Pi was an irrational number. After learning this, I wrote “Let’s make some irrational decisions together.” Though it’s difficult to trace the lineage of inspiration, I like to think that this line gave us the emotional permission needed to “get weird,” as it were.

Though it’s not a “traditional” copywriting deliverable, I wrote a Pi Day sketch for the DevRel team based on the telephone game, in which a message is increasingly garbled as it is retold.



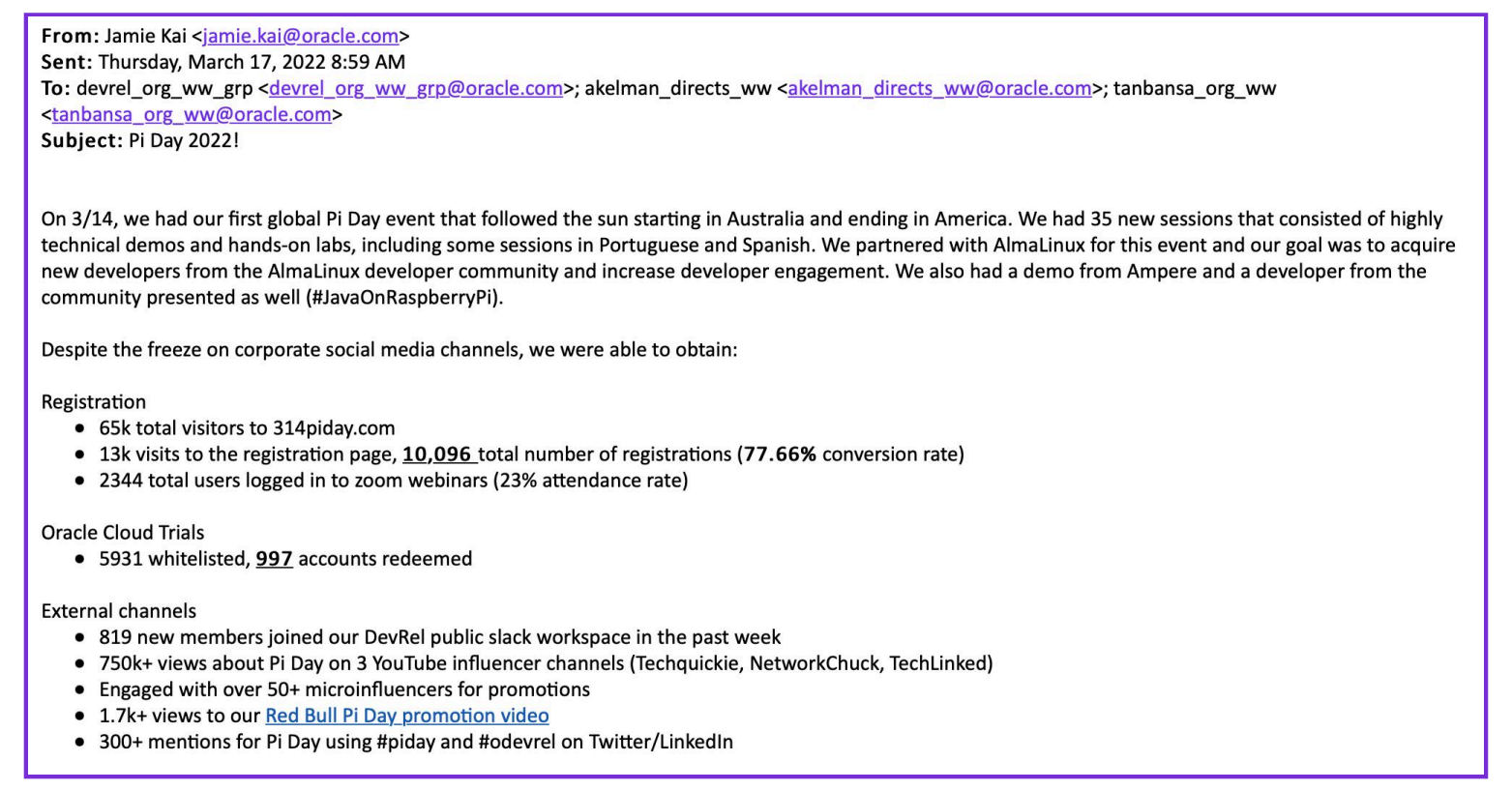
Let’s make some irrational decisions together

My thinking was to make event information entertaining by parceling it out with new faces and interspersed by facts that have nothing to do with the event. The sketch ends with Bo telling us there won’t be pie at the event. I wrote the script, recruited participants, and gathered footage for the video content team to edit.

Their editing rendered these exchanges using a look similar to FaceTime, emphasizing the “telephone” in the telephone game bit.

RESULT

Pi Day was our most successful event of 2022. See the “External Channels” heading in the internal debrief of the event for numbers relevant to social copy.



From: Jamie Kai <jamie.kai@oracle.com>
Sent: Thursday, March 17, 2022 8:59 AM
To: devrel_org_ww_grp <devrel_org_ww_grp@oracle.com>; akelman_directs_ww <akelman_directs_ww@oracle.com>; tanbansa_org_ww <tanbansa_org_ww@oracle.com>
Subject: Pi Day 2022!

On 3/14, we had our first global Pi Day event that followed the sun starting in Australia and ending in America. We had 35 new sessions that consisted of highly technical demos and hands-on labs, including some sessions in Portuguese and Spanish. We partnered with AlmaLinux for this event and our goal was to acquire new developers from the AlmaLinux developer community and increase developer engagement. We also had a demo from Ampere and a developer from the community presented as well (#JavaOnRaspberryPi).

Despite the freeze on corporate social media channels, we were able to obtain:

Registration
- 65k total visitors to 314piday.com
- 13k visits to the registration page, **10,096** total number of registrations (**77.66%** conversion rate)
- 2344 total users logged in to zoom webinars (23% attendance rate)

Oracle Cloud Trials
- 5931 whitelisted, **997** accounts redeemed

External channels
- 819 new members joined our DevRel public slack workspace in the past week
- 750k+ views about Pi Day on 3 YouTube influencer channels (Techquickie, NetworkChuck, TechLinked)
- Engaged with over 50+ microinfluencers for promotions
- 1.7k+ views to our Red Bull Pi Day promotion video
- 300+ mentions for Pi Day using #piday and #odevrel on Twitter/LinkedIn

As an aside, I did name the character of Razzy (whose spelling I don’t think has been codified yet). It looks like this character will be used for events this year, 2023, as well.

Case Study: Defining Product Messaging Under Organizational Ambiguity

Oracle DevWeek

CONTEXT AND UNCERTAINTY

This project launched without clear requirements, timelines, or final positioning, requiring copy to function as a sense-making tool.

The details of this currently ongoing project have been opaque. From copy deliverables to messaging, leadership has been slow to provide requirements. In the meantime, I’m creating an angle that I hope will be adopted towards what we do know we’ll need - tweets, blogs, carousel messaging, social tiles, etc.

GOALS AND CONSTRAINTS

The task here is to (1) navigate ambiguity and (2) find an angle of overall messaging that resonates with my stakeholders (many people, though primarily Caroline Caldwell).

In my experience, even if it doesn’t go anywhere, starting a conversation with a draft elicits reactions and it’s from there you can start to focus on what The Ask is.

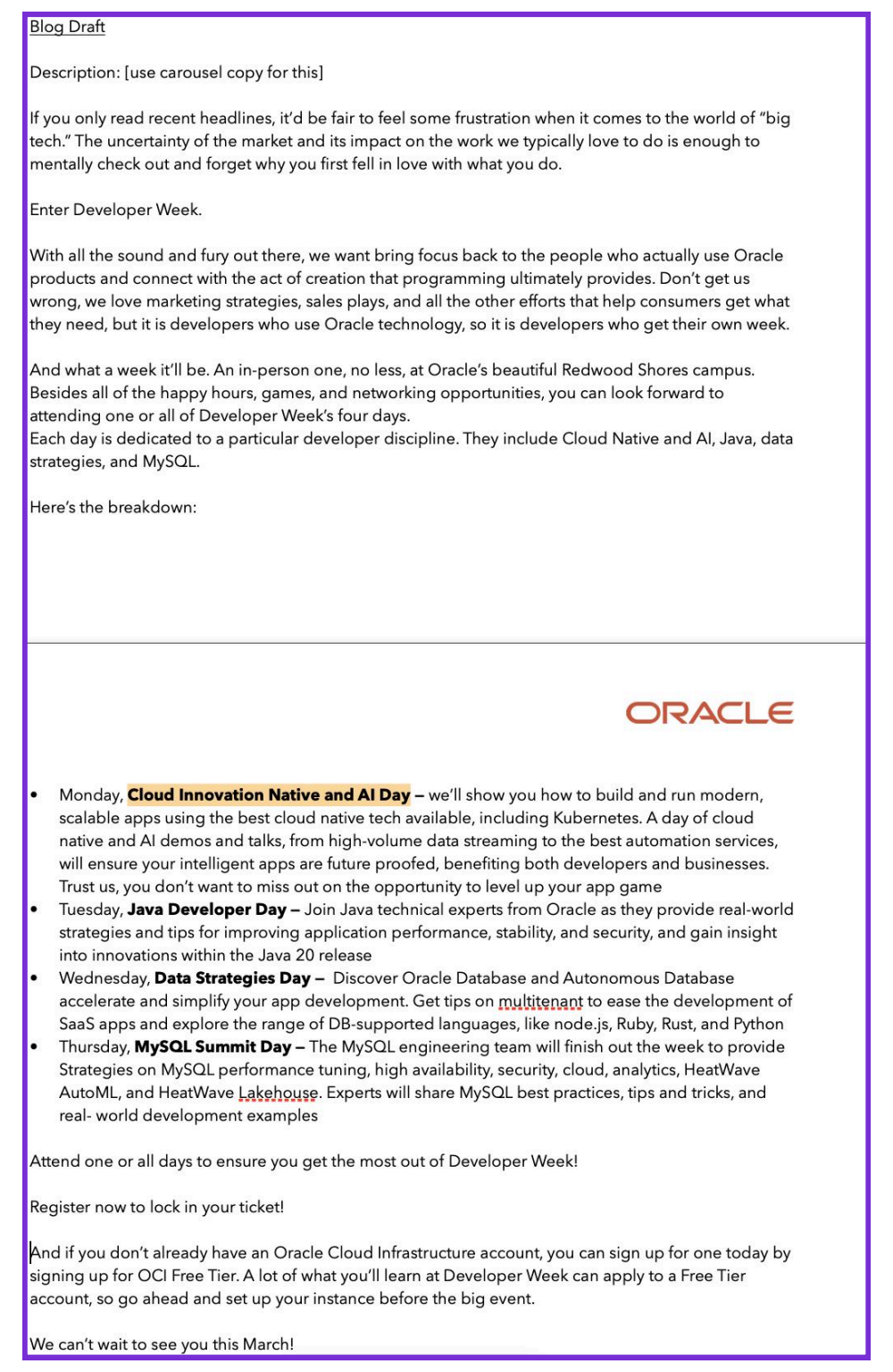
MESSAGING SYSTEM AND DECISIONS

Rather than waiting for finalized requirements, I used draft copy to surface assumptions, test tone, and align stakeholders.

The DevWeek event uses Oracle’s “corporate” voice, which deemphasizes playfulness, so this event does not call for a unique or clever voice. Using a tone that spins away from irreverence and maximizes clarity using plain language, I want to leverage the real-world, material threats that are currently a reality to developers.

That means acknowledging economic conditions which translate into threats of layoffs. But doing so in a way that isn’t too scary. This isn’t playful, this isn’t clever - this event is a time of focus and a time to rediscover the very thing you fell in love with in the first place: building things with code (read: development).

A note - I did not write the day descriptions. Reps from those teams submitted their own copy.



Blog Draft

Description: [use carousel copy for this]

If you only read recent headlines, it’d be fair to feel some frustration when it comes to the world of “big tech.” The uncertainty of the market and its impact on the work we typically love to do is enough to mentally check out and forget why you first fell in love with what you do.

Enter Developer Week.

With all the sound and fury out there, we want bring focus back to the people who actually use Oracle products and connect with the act of creation that programming ultimately provides. Don’t get us wrong, we love marketing strategies, sales plays, and all the other efforts that help consumers get what they need, but it is developers who use Oracle technology, so it is developers who get their own week.

And what a week it’ll be. An in-person one, no less, at Oracle’s beautiful Redwood Shores campus. Besides all of the happy hours, games, and networking opportunities, you can look forward to attending one or all of Developer Week’s four days.
Each day is dedicated to a particular developer discipline. They include Cloud Native and AI, Java, data strategies, and MySQL.

Here’s the breakdown:

ORACLE

- Monday, **Cloud Innovation Native and AI Day** – we’ll show you how to build and run modern, scalable apps using the best cloud native tech available, including Kubernetes. A day of cloud native and AI demos and talks, from high-volume data streaming to the best automation services, will ensure your intelligent apps are future proofed, benefiting both developers and businesses. Trust us, you don’t want to miss out on the opportunity to level up your app game
- Tuesday, **Java Developer Day** – Join Java technical experts from Oracle as they provide real-world strategies and tips for improving application performance, stability, and security, and gain insight into innovations within the Java 20 release
- Wednesday, **Data Strategies Day** – Discover Oracle Database and Autonomous Database accelerate and simplify your app development. Get tips on multitenant to ease the development of SaaS apps and explore the range of DB-supported languages, like node.js, Ruby, Rust, and Python
- Thursday, **MySQL Summit Day** – The MySQL engineering team will finish out the week to provide Strategies on MySQL performance tuning, high availability, security, cloud, analytics, HeatWave AutoML, and HeatWave Lakehouse. Experts will share MySQL best practices, tips and tricks, and real- world development examples

Attend one or all days to ensure you get the most out of Developer Week!

Register now to lock in your ticket!

And if you don’t already have an Oracle Cloud Infrastructure account, you can sign up for one today by signing up for OCI Free Tier. A lot of what you’ll learn at Developer Week can apply to a Free Tier account, so go ahead and set up your instance before the big event.

We can’t wait to see you this March!

RESULT
While final messaging was still evolving, early drafts successfully aligned stakeholders around a more grounded, developer-first narrative.

Preliminary discussions with stakeholders pointed towards buy-in regarding the angle of homecoming for developers - getting back to their roots and focusing on what they love.

WHAT WOULD I CHANGE?

I’m of two minds about the exclamation marks at the end of this blog post. On one hand, this is a CTA for an *in-person* event and that truly is exciting. On the other, I worry that this attitude doesn’t match the cold-splash-of-water-in-the-face with which the entry begins.

Case Study: Managing Accuracy, Tone, and Trust in Developer-Facing Content

Customer Success Story, Cohere AI (link to story)

CONTEXT & RISK SURFACE
This work involved high technical and reputational risk, requiring strict accuracy, validation, and tone controls.

As part of Oracle’s Product Marketing team, I supported a shift from marketing Oracle Cloud Infrastructure to developers and enterprise audiences to marketing Oracle’s AI offerings, including Oracle’s AI coding companion and its graphics processing units (GPUs).

GOALS AND CONSTRAINTS
Part of the focus-shift from OCI to AI meant that Oracle needed to use all the arrows in its quiver to pivot its identity as not just the company known for database, Java, and ERP services, but one that empowers customers to do those things and more with the added power of AI.

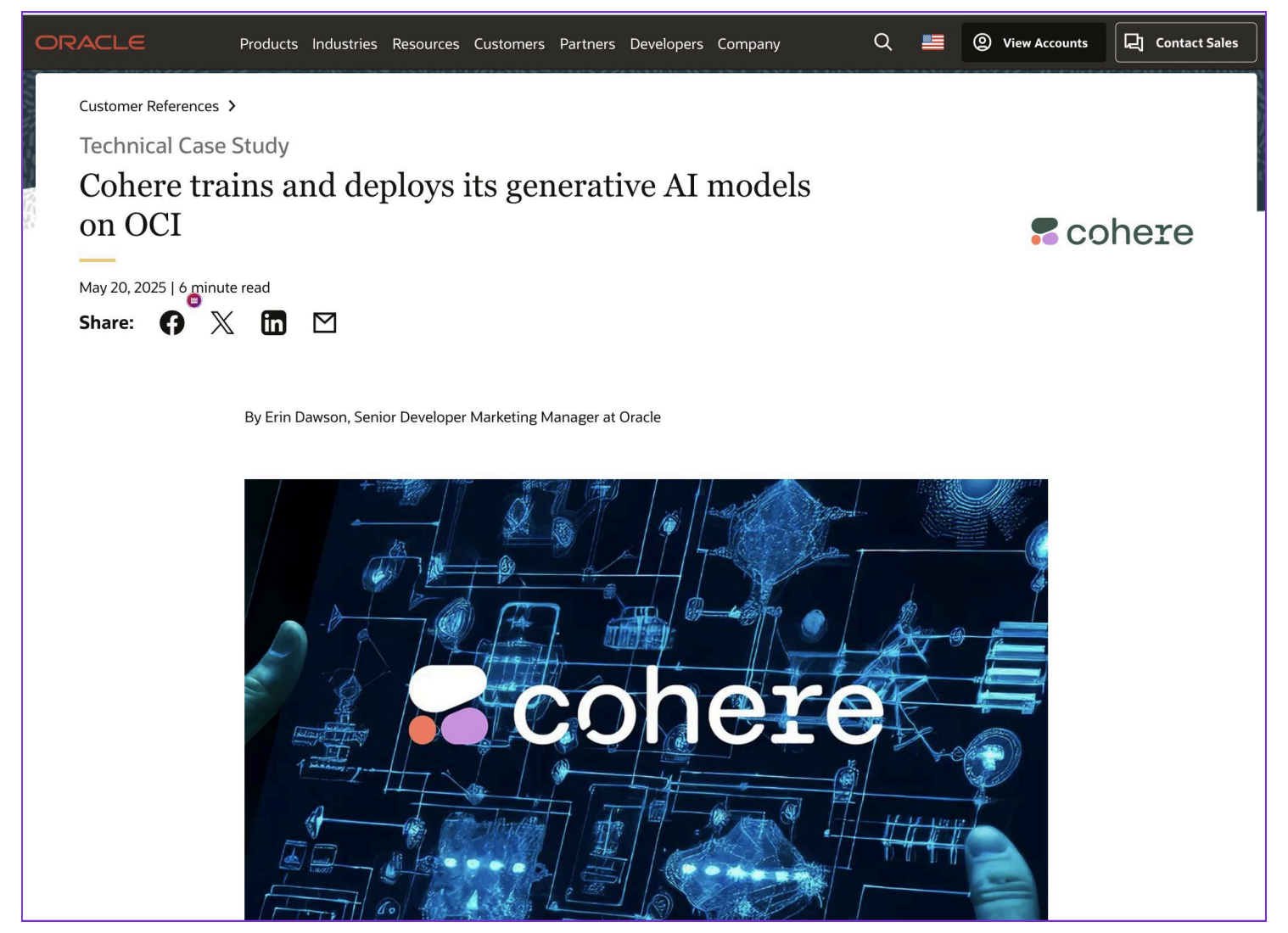
Technical Customer success stories are one of those arrows in that quiver.

This meant that I needed to write a customer success story demonstrating that Oracle is not just positioned to help organizations level up with AI, but that we can also help them transition to use Oracle’s GPUs which AI companies use to train their LLMs.

CONTENT SYSTEM AND VALIDATION WORKFLOW
I treated this deliverable as a governed content system, not a one-off piece.

One of these customer success stories highlighted Cohere, an AI platform, which used two Oracle products to train their LLM — Oracle Kubernetes Engine (OKE) and Oracle’s GPUs. For this story, we chose to highlight Cohere’s benefitting from Oracle’s GPUs and how easy the transition to using our services was.

The process for writing this deliverable meant working cross-collaboratively: technical experts on Oracle’s side were invited to the interviews I had with Cohere to fact check the deeply technical aspects of Cohere’s usage of Oracle’s services and fact-check, yours truly to interview the customer, Cohere’s engineers, and their subject matter expert (SME) who managed their end of this collaboration, providing ultimate signoff for what they did and did not want published.



Customer References >

Technical Case Study

Cohere trains and deploys its generative AI models on OCI

May 20, 2025 | 6 minute read

By Erin Dawson, Senior Developer Marketing Manager at Oracle

RESULT
Over approximately three months, I worked with Cohere, Oracle’s engineers, and my organizations’s leadership to arrive at a draft all parties were comfortable with.

This technical case study was published on Oracle.com, posted to LinkedIn on the Oracle Developers page, and reposted by Cohere.

WHAT WOULD I CHANGE?
Nothing here strikes me as needing overhauled. The piece combines approachable tone with highly technical information which does not come off as commercial. It also uses quotes from experts to provide additional legitimacy and a softening human element, which I find helps in a piece of this length and technical specificity. “In future iterations, these validation steps could be formalized into reusable documentation or tooling to support similar stories